



Number of visas issued drops off

After policy changes, fewer immigrants are coming to the U.S. legally

BY LAUREN KAORI GURLEY AND FEDERICA COCCO

The United States issued about a quarter million fewer visas in the first eight months of 2025 compared with the same period in 2024, as the Trump administration introduced policies that have reshaped who comes to the United States legally.

From January to August 2025, the State Department approved 11 percent fewer permanent resident and temporary visas compared with the same period a year before, according to State Department data released in early March. These visas are generally issued for students, workers, and family members of citizens and legal residents. The 11 percent drop doesn't include tourist visas, which also fell during the same period.

India and China bore the brunt of the visa declines. The U.S. issued many fewer temporary visas to international students, cultural exchange visitors, and fiancés and spouses of U.S. citizens from those countries and beyond.

Visa approvals for permanent residency — known as green cards — also declined, with the largest drops in visas for workers, certain relatives, and Iraqi and Afghan nationals who worked with the U.S. military.

Most nations sent fewer immigrants to the United States. In a group of 61 countries with at least 5,000 visa approvals from January to August 2024, just seven received more visas in 2025 than the year before.

SEE VISAS ON A5



HEIDI LEVINE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

David Azran, 54, sits barefoot in his family's home on Sunday after it was damaged in an Iranian missile attack. Israel's air defenses failed to intercept two barrages, resulting in direct hits in the southern towns of Dimona and Arad and leaving more than 100 people wounded.

Trump's solution to TSA absences: Just add ICE

BY EMILY DAVIES AND MARIANA ALFARO

President Donald Trump said he is sending U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents to airports Monday, after threatening to do so unless congressional Democrats agree to a GOP-backed funding deal.

"ICE will be going to airports to help our wonderful TSA Agents," Trump said in a social media post on Sunday morning, escalating a standoff over the funding deal that has caused a partial government shutdown and slowed security lines at airports nationwide.

He intensified the pressure Sunday evening, instructing Sen-

Agents are expected at Atlanta International on Monday, mayor says

ate Republicans in another post to refuse a deal unless Democrats back a bill requiring proof of citizenship for voter registration and photo identification at the polls, among other voting restrictions.

Senate Democrats unanimously oppose the bill, which Senate Minority Leader Charles E. Schumer (D-New York) has warned would make it harder to vote, describing it as "Jim Crow

2.0." Republicans control the Senate 53-47, and the bill would require 60 votes to overcome a filibuster, giving it no path to passage. Deploying ICE agents to checkpoints nationwide would mark an unprecedented expansion of immigration enforcement even as Democrats push for tighter limits on how those agents operate, citing concerns that the administration has fast-tracked training to expand ICE's ranks. Agents from Homeland Security Investigations, who focus on criminal investigations, and officers who specialize in detention and deportation are expected to be at the Atlanta International Airport on Monday, the city's may-

or said in a statement.

Mayor Andre Dickens, in the statement, said that "federal officials have indicated that this deployment is not intended to conduct immigration enforcement activities."

In an earlier post to Truth Social over the weekend, Trump said the ICE agents would "do Security like no one has ever seen before, including the immediate arrest of all Illegal Immigrants who have come into our Country, with heavy emphasis on those from Somalia."

Speaking to CNN's "State of the Union" on Sunday morning, White House border czar Tom Homan said the administration is

SEE ICE ON A4

Russian 'Gamechanger': A fake assassination plot

Proposal seen as a way to boost Kremlin-friendly Hungarian leader in polls

BY CATHERINE BELTON

BUDAPEST — In the run-up to Hungary's pivotal election in April, a unit of Russia's foreign intelligence service last month began sounding the alarm over plummeting public support for Prime Minister Viktor Orban, whose friendly ties to Moscow have long given the Kremlin a strategic foothold inside NATO and the European Union.

Officers from the intelligence service, or SVR, suggested that drastic action might be necessary — a strategy they called "the Gamechanger." In an internal report for the SVR obtained and authenticated by a European intelligence service and reviewed by The Washington Post, the operatives proposed a way to "fundamentally alter the entire paradigm of the election campaign" — "the staging of an assassination attempt on Viktor Orban."

"Such an incident will shift the perception of the campaign out of the rational realm of socioeconomic questions into an emotional one, where the key themes will become state security and

the stability and defense of the political system," the operatives wrote in a report prepared for the SVR's main unit for political influence operations, Directorate MS, or Active Measures Department.

There have been no physical attacks on Orban, whose popularity has eroded because of a worsening economy. But the mere suggestion of staging an attempt on Orban's life underscores how high the stakes are for Moscow in the Hungarian race.

The July 2024 campaign-trail attack in which Donald Trump was grazed by a would-be assassin's bullet resulted in iconic photos of him, praise for his resilience, and a quick bump in his poll numbers, especially among core supporters.

Polls show Orban trailing Peter Magyar, who is also conservative and a former member of Orban's party, Fidesz, but campaigning as an anti-corruption reformer. "The majority (52.3 percent) are dissatisfied with the state of affairs in the country," the Russian officers wrote. "The dissatisfaction prevails not only in cities but also in the rural areas (50.8 percent) where traditionally the ruling Fidesz party's position is strong."

Russia is not the only outside power potentially looking to prop up Orban in one of the toughest campaigns of his career.

SEE HUNGARY ON A13



DANIELLE VILLASANA/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

An 80-mile ride. Endless meaning.

Annual horseback journey connects Black families to their Texas roots

BY MOLLY HENNESSY-FISKE

HEMPSTEAD, TEXAS — Among the dozen trail rides making their annual journey to celebrate the start of Houston's rodeo this month, Prairie View is unique. The first all-Black trail ride, Prairie View was named after Texas's first historically Black public university. Its 80-mile, week-long trek takes riders from a rural pasture across farm roads and suburban highway overpasses to Houston's Memorial Park. For many, it's also a journey

back in time.

Mia Johnson, 56, relished the start of the Prairie View pilgrimage that has defined her life for more than half a century. Raised Catholic, she attends church regularly and posts daily online "cowboy prayers." She was "gung ho" for Donald Trump in 2016 "because I'm from the military, that 'kick 'em in the butt' attitude," though the Army veteran soured on what she perceived as Trump's mistreatment of veterans. For Mia and

SEE TRAIL ON A6

The Prairie View Trail Rider Association, founded in 1957, is known as the "Mother of Black Trails" and was the first all-Black trail ride. The week-long trek goes from Hempstead to Houston.

Eyeing war's final stages

BATTLE FOR HORMUZ IS POSSIBLE ENDGAME

Trump threats, U.S. troop buildup raise the stakes

BY GREG MILLER, RACHEL CHASON, SAMMY WESTFALL AND HEIDI LEVINE

TEL AVIV — A surge of additional U.S. forces to the Middle East and President Donald Trump's threat to "obliterate" Iran's energy infrastructure have set the stage for what U.S. and Israeli security officials increasingly see as the war's possible endgame: a battle for control of the Strait of Hormuz and key energy installations.

Reopening the strait — a critical conduit for global energy supplies — has emerged as perhaps the paramount objective of a war that security officials now believe is unlikely to achieve goals that briefly seemed possible at the outset of the U.S.-Israeli military operation, including overthrowing Iran's theocratic regime and putting a nuclear weapon permanently out of Tehran's reach.

Instead, breaking Iran's stranglehold on the strait could enable Trump to wind down the war while claiming victory, halt an expanding global energy crisis and deprive Iran of a potent deterrent against future strikes — which senior Israeli officials described as inevitable if Tehran resumes ballistic missile production or moves to develop a nuclear weapon.

SEE MIDEAST ON A12

His message: Kent wants Trump to hear MAGA opposition to war. A9

Four truths about covid that time has clouded over

BY FENIT NIRAPPIL

Unlike in a hurricane or war zone, much of covid's toll happened out of public view, inside the crowded hospitals where people died on ventilators, often without families by their side in the early months. Frustration built among millions of Americans who were largely stuck at home and required to wear masks at stores as kids learned via Zoom because of an invisible threat. Glimpses came through in the haunting stream of ambulances in empty New York City streets or images of overflowing morgues.

"These are traumatic experiences, and in many ways the ways we deal with it is to forget and move on," said Ziyad Al-Aly, a physician-scientist and senior clinical epidemiologist at Washington University in St. Louis who treated covid patients and has been extensively researching the long-term consequences of the virus. "A lot of Americans don't really remember those days, but we lived each one of them."

This disconnect has led to misconceptions years later, according to public health experts. Hindsight, the distance of time and the now endemic nature of

SEE COVID ON A2

IN THE NEWS

NCAA tournament The Maryland women and Virginia men are bounced out of the second round of March Madness in tough losses. C1

Polarizing history Years after protesters in Baltimore toppled a Christopher Columbus statue in 2020, President Donald Trump has installed a re-creation at the White House. A9

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The administration faces complicated political dynamics as it seeks a new head of the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, which has had a prolonged leadership vacuum. A3

THE WORLD

Nicolás Maduro's authoritarian regime held hundreds of political prisoners in Venezuela. A Post reporter was there for the reunion of one couple after more than a year apart. A10

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Activists who fought sexual violence against women farmworkers cope with the César Chavez allegations. A16

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Gwyneth Paltrow's wardrobe is up for auction. It's more wearable than you might think. B1

"Arirang," the new album from BTS, is both a reintroduction to the K-pop boy band and a keen reminder of its place in pop culture. B1

THE REGION

A bullied teen became a political symbol for Trump. Her real story is far worse. C7

The cherry blossoms at the Tidal Basin could reach "peak bloom" stage within a week. C7

HEALTH & SCIENCE

Food-scanning app Yuka is empowering consumers to demand that processed food brands make their products healthier. D1

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